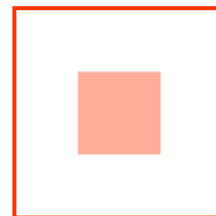

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap — A data-driven overview for policy analysts and program planners

Source: Our World in Data / IHME Global Burden of Disease (2023)



**Hundreds of Millions Affected:
1 in 3 Women and 1 in 5 Men Face Major
Depression**

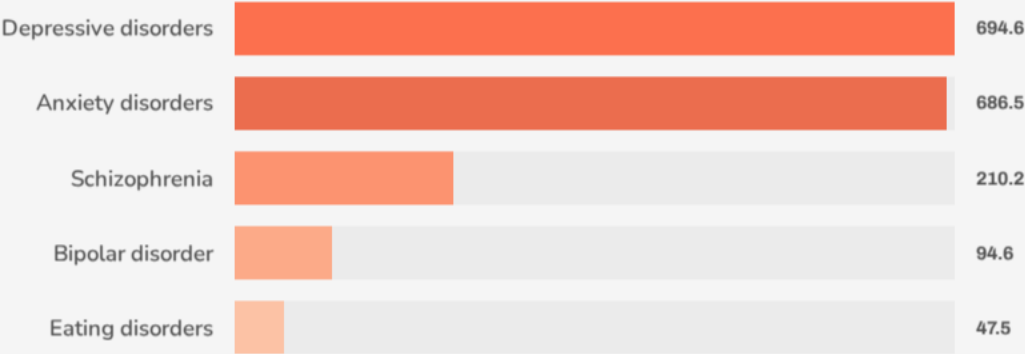
1 in 3 1 in 5

WOMEN

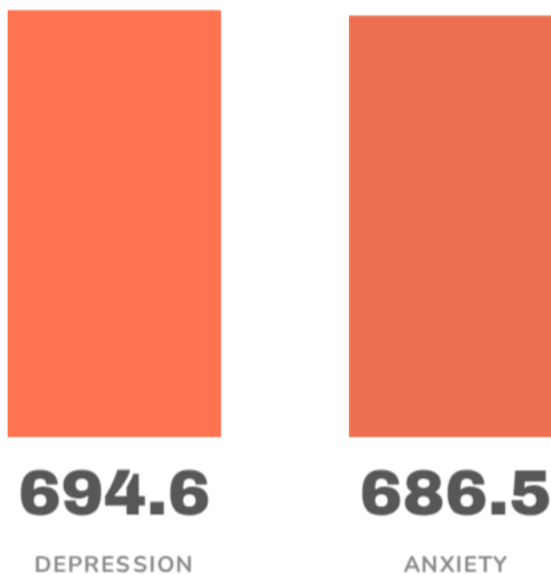
MEN



**Depression and Anxiety Dominate:
~695 and ~687 DALYs per 100K
Respectively**



Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden Worldwide



Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder: Lower Prevalence but Severe Individual Impact

Schizophrenia

210.2

DALYs per 100,000 people. While affecting fewer people, schizophrenia contributes a substantial population-level burden — reflecting the severe disability associated with the condition.

Bipolar Disorder

94.6

DALYs per 100,000 people. A smaller but meaningful share of total mental health burden, with high individual severity requiring specialized, sustained care.



Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality



STIGMA

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or even to people they know.



ACCESS

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries where resources are scarce.



QUALITY

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality — ineffective, unsafe, or poorly delivered.



UNDERREPORTING

Discomfort with disclosure makes it difficult to estimate true prevalence; the actual burden may be higher.



How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings where pharmaceutical access and mental health infrastructure are more developed.



Religious or Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide, reflecting the cultural and community-based dimensions of mental health response.



Talking to Friends or Family

A widely reported coping mechanism across cultures, highlighting the importance of social support networks.

The diversity of coping strategies underscores that mental health responses are shaped by cultural, economic, and healthcare system factors. Policy interventions must account for these differences rather than applying a one-size-fits-all approach.



Key Takeaways: Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Treatment Gap

- 1** Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs — roughly 80% across the five major categories.
- 2** Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder carry disproportionate individual burden relative to prevalence and require specialized, sustained care.
- 3** Effective treatment exists, but access and quality remain inadequate — particularly in low- and middle-income countries.
- 4** Stigma suppresses both help-seeking behavior and accurate data collection, meaning the true burden is likely underestimated.
- 5** Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.

